

STAMP OF A SCAM

■ By Mihir Srivastava

In India, there's the stamp of a scam evident in almost every government department that makes a mockery of rules and laws. Here's one that comes from the most unexpected quarter: the postal department. It's officially called the Department of Posts, under the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology, but the core of the scam lies in the information that is being regularly leaked so that dubious dealers, including some in countries like Pakistan, can make a killing by acquiring stamps and first day covers, weeks, even months, before they are officially released by the government of India. Hard core stamp collectors are willing to pay large sums of money to get their hands on a stamp that has not been officially released.

In fact, so blatant is the racket that pre-release Indian stamps are being freely traded via philately websites all over the world. It's a little like the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) printing new denominations of currency notes which are available in the market even before the apex financial body officially puts it out. Of course, stamps are not currency notes, but it's a treasury item that cannot move into the public domain before its official release. Philately material carries a cautionary note in red, bold capital letters that says: "Not to be issued to the public till the instructions are received from the director general, posts, about the date of the release." Needless to say, the guideline is being ignored while people in the department, in league with dealers, go on to make some illicit money.

Examples abound. The perfumed stamp sheets of Jasmine were being sold by a dealer in Pakistan (code name of the dealer is Fdc4u, believed to be a leading one) on February 28, 2008 on the global philately trading portal delcampe.net. This was two months before its official release on April 26, 2008. In the item description, he makes



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a strong sales pitch, "this is a pre-issue sheet and its issue date has been postponed". Similarly, INDIA TODAY has records of the sale of collectors' stamps like Aldabra Giant Turtles, which was being freely sold months before its release. The Indian Coast Guard stamp worth Rs 20 was being sold with impunity on the Internet for Rs 869 in May; this stamp is still to be released. There are plenty more and the evidence points to one dealer based in Delhi. His code name is Stamp4evr on delcampe.net. He changes his name frequently to avoid identification, one of his earlier names was Tappu.

INDIA TODAY's investigations reveal that the real name of Tappu alias Stamp4evr is Vinod Sabarwal. He is a resident of Paschim Vihar, Delhi. The staff at the Delhi Philately Bureau con-

firm he is a regular and is well connected in the bureau. Popularly known as Dak Bhawan, the building in Delhi houses the bureau and the Department of Posts from where its top functionaries operate. Thus, this philately scam is carried out right under the noses of the top officials of the department.

This is how the scam works. By one estimate there would be 2,50,000 serious philately enthusiasts in India. The Department of Posts releases two types of stamps: commemorative and definitive stamps. The former are collection items as they are released, as the name suggests, to commemorate important events, personalities, national or international issues or to celebrate nature, rare flora and fauna. They are available only at the 68 philatelic bureaux opened all over the country or under